

PORTABLE MEDIA PLAYERS

In 2006, it was MP3 players that we tested under this genre. 2007 saw things change. There was video playability prominently featured on almost every device, barring a few odd ones. In addition, there were features such as calendar, syncing with the PC e-mail client, etc. added to the spec-sheet. The devices were therefore referred to as Personal Media Players (PMPs).

UP TO RS 5,000

The Reigning Champion

SanDisk Sansa c240

The "Lil Monsta", as it's called, looks unassuming, is sleek like a USB stick, and has top-class build quality. There is 1 GB of internal memory, though this can be augmented by means of a MicroSD card. The Li-Ion battery lasted us 13.5 hours, which is pretty good considering the fact that it has an LCD screen rather than the power-efficient OLED.

The Contender

Transcend T.sonic 840

This is a brand-new MP3 player, the replacement for the T.sonic 630 models that followed the 610. The major upgrade has been that the 1.8-inch screen does a resolution of 176 x 220. This means you can now use this device to read books as well. You can find the 4 GB version of this player for just under Rs 5,000.

The Award

Transcend T.sonic 840

The Transcend T.sonic 840 is brilliant value for its price, and displaces the Sansa c240 as the Zero1 winner. A fresh new design, the large number of features, and loads of memory make it a very good buy for almost anyone. There's even a 2 GB version for Rs 600 to 700 lesser.



RS 5,001 TO RS 10,000

The Reigning Champion

SanDisk Sansa e250

This one has it all: FM radio, voice recording, video playback, photo viewing, cus-

tomisable equaliser, and expansion—you name it! It looks good, too, with the best-built, scratch-proof titanium alloy back. There is support for custom playlists and equalisers, and it can read media stored inside folders.

The Contenders

Apple iPod nano 8 GB (third generation)

The new iPod nano 8 GB has improved on the shortcomings of the older nano. This one has a 2-inch screen for video. It's wide, but it's still tiny, and more importantly, it's light. Dropping memory prices means that now, an 8 GB MP3 player is around Rs 8,500. The Sansa needs to put out something special if it is to keep its top spot!

The Award

Apple iPod nano 8 GB (third generation)

Improvements and upgrades have made the nano better than ever. The iPod nano 8 GB (third generation) wins the Zero1 award in this, the mid-range PMP category. When the older nano (2 GB) was around, it was priced around Rs 8,150. This one makes much more sense. Users already using a Nano might not find this worth the buy, but for those looking for something under Rs 10,000—there's nothing as good as this. It's a lot about the styling and good pricing.



ABOVE RS 10,000

The Reigning Champion

Cowon D2

A great looker, this PMP has a rather large touchscreen—a brilliant 16 million colour display. Although it is made of plastic, the build quality is very good. The touchscreen is the only interface, and therefore there aren't many buttons—a stylus is provided to aid in navigating the slick icon-based interface; not that it's required—you can even use your fingertips. It supports a wide range of audio formats, but there is native support for only two video formats—AVI and MPEG. This issue, however, is taken care of by the bundled converter software. If the 4 GB capacity falls short, there is the option to add in an SD card.

The Contender

Apple iPod Touch

There's no better contender for the Cowon D2 than the latest and most talked-of gadget from Apple—the iPod Touch. It's similar to the iPhone, except, of course, there's no phone. The Touch

tag indicates a touchscreen, and unlike the ones you find on some phones, this one uses multi-touches to allow you to flip through albums, scroll, and resize. This is clearly a threat to the dominance of the Cowon D2.

The Award

Apple iPod Touch

The iPod Touch comes in two flavours—8 GB and 16 GB. It's possible to find the 8 GB model for around Rs 14,000 in Indian markets—an absolute killer price. Audio,



video, photos, Web browsing, you name it—the Touch has it. Think about it—you can even use it to watch YouTube videos! It'd be unfair to not award it the Zero1 in this category; people love it, and we do, too.

PROCESSORS

A lot has changed from the Pentium and Athlon series of yore. Intel's Core 2 Duo (C2D) is a breed apart and the reigning champions of the number crunching game. AMD has lost the race for now, and with their Phenoms failing to deliver, there's nothing to stop Intel's juggernaut. It's only in the value segment that we see AMD fitting nicely; some AMD processors offer the best bang for the buck.

THE BEST DESKTOP PROCESSOR

The Reigning Champion

Intel QX6850

The QX6850 is Intel's flagship processor—which we'd tested in our annual comparison—and it performs admirably. Though it's a quasi-quad-core, its performance in multi-threaded application is breathtaking. With 8 MB of L2 cache and 1333 MHz FSB, the QX6850 running at 3 GHz just zips through most applications. Retailing at Rs 45,000, the QX6850 is very expensive, but with there being absolutely no competition, you should expect to cough up that sort of money!

The Contender

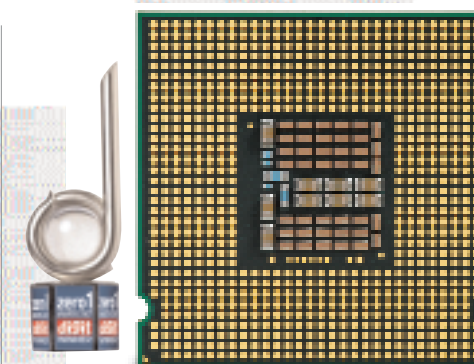
Intel QX9650 (Penryn)

Within a month of our processor shootout, Intel unleashed quite something else—the QX9650, the first 45-nanometre silicon piece. Running at 3 GHz, with a 1333 MHz FSB, it has a 6 MB cache per die—a huge 12 MB in all. Built on a 45nm process, the QX9650 is much more power-efficient as compared to its older sibling. The addition of 47 new instructions under SSE4 gives a big boost to multimedia applications. Overall, we saw a nice 7 to 10 per cent boost in performance across our tests. Retailing at Rs 50,000, the QX9650 is definitely a step in the right direction.

The Award

Intel QX9650

If money is no bar, Intel's Core 2 Extreme QX9650 is definitely the processor to go for, and given the performance advantage, we have no hesitation in awarding it our coveted Zero1 award for the best Desktop processor.



A PROCESSOR FOR EVERYONE

The Reigning champion

Intel Core 2 Quad Q6600

The Intel Q6600 is in its own class; no processor can hold a candle to its excellent performance / price ratio; it is sweetly priced at Rs 11,500. The newer AMD Phenom processors have had a hard time trying to beat the Q6600...

The Contenders

AMD Phenom 9600 and 9700

Based on pricing and clock speed, the Phenom 9600 and 9700 are the real contenders to the Intel Core 2 Quad Q6600. However, availability and compatibility with existing hardware will be an issue for the new Phenoms. Further, the Q6600 offers better performance than both the new AMD processors.

The Award

Intel Q6600

For now, it's a one-sided game; the Q6600 is the clear winner. It rules supreme and is the processor to buy to build a gaming or multimedia PC. It gets our Zero1 award for its performance as well as pricing.

